Data extracted on 22 April 2026. | Planned article update: 21 October 2026.

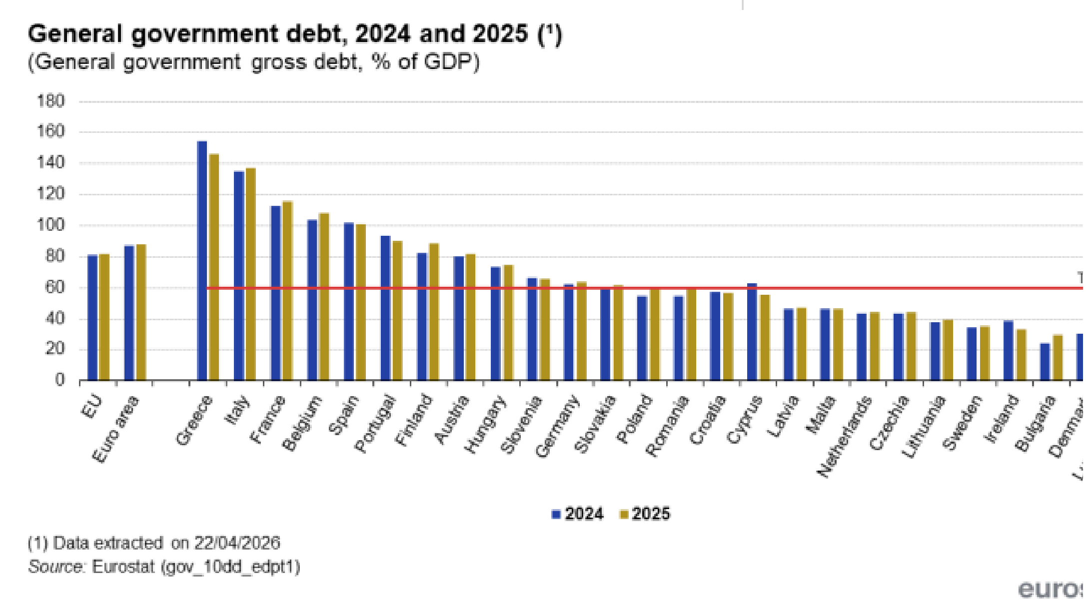
Government finance statistics

Highlights

In the euro area the government deficit to GDP ratio decreased from -3.0% in 2024 to -2.9% in 2025, and in the EU it remained unchanged at -3.1%.

In the euro area the government debt to GDP ratio increased from 87.0% at the end of 2024 to 87.8% at the end of 2025; in the EU it increased from 80.7% to 81.7%.

At the end of 2025, the government debt to GDP ratio ranged from 24.1% in Estonia to 146.1% in Greece.



Source: Eurostat (gov_10dd_edpt1)

This article examines how key government finance statistics have developed in the European Union (EU) and the euro area (EA). Specifically, it considers general government deficits, gross debt, total revenue and total expenditure, as well as taxes and social contributions, which are the main sources of government revenue.

Introduction

Government finance statistics contain crucial indicators for determining the health of the economies of the EU Member States. Under the terms of the EU's Stability and Growth Pact (SGP), Member States pledged to keep their deficits and debt below certain limits: a Member State's government deficit may not exceed 3% of its gross domestic product (GDP), while its debt may not exceed 60% of GDP. If a Member State does not respect these limits, the so-called excessive deficit procedure (EDP) is triggered. This entails several steps — including the possibility of sanctions — to encourage the Member State concerned to take appropriate measures to rectify the situation. The same deficit and debt limits are also criteria for economic and monetary union (EMU) and hence for joining the euro.

In the euro area (EA20) the government deficit to GDP ratio decreased from -3.0% in 2024 to -2.9% in 2025, and in the EU it remained unchanged at -3.1% in 2025. In the euro area the government debt to GDP ratio increased from 87.0% at the end of 2024 to 87.8% at the end of 2025, and in the EU it increased from 80.7% to 81.7%.

General government surplus/deficit

The EU's government deficit-to-GDP ratio remained unchanged at -3.1% in 2025 and in the euro area decreased from -3.0% in 2024 to -2.9% in 2025.

In 2021 and 2022, deficits decreased after the highest values in the time series (-7.0% for the euro area and -6.7% for the EU) had been recorded in 2020. The economic downturn caused by the COVID-19 pandemic, as evidenced by a drop in nominal GDP between 2019 and 2020, as well as the expenditure measures to contain the economic and social impact of the COVID-19 pandemic had a strong impact on the deficit and debt ratios in 2020. In 2022, 2023 and to a much lesser extent in 2024 and 2025, the high energy prices and the measures undertaken by EU governments to alleviate their impact, influenced the government balance, so that for the EU and euro area, deficits remained at a relatively elevated level.

In 2025, all Member States, except Cyprus (+3.4%), Denmark (+2.9%), Ireland (+1.8%), Greece (+1.7%) and Portugal (+0.7%), reported a deficit. The highest deficits were recorded in Romania (-7.9%), Poland (-7.3%), Belgium (-5.2%) and France (-5.1%). In total, 11 Member States had deficits higher or equal to 3% of GDP: Romania, Poland, Belgium, France, Hungary, Slovakia, Austria, Bulgaria, Finland, Italy and Croatia.

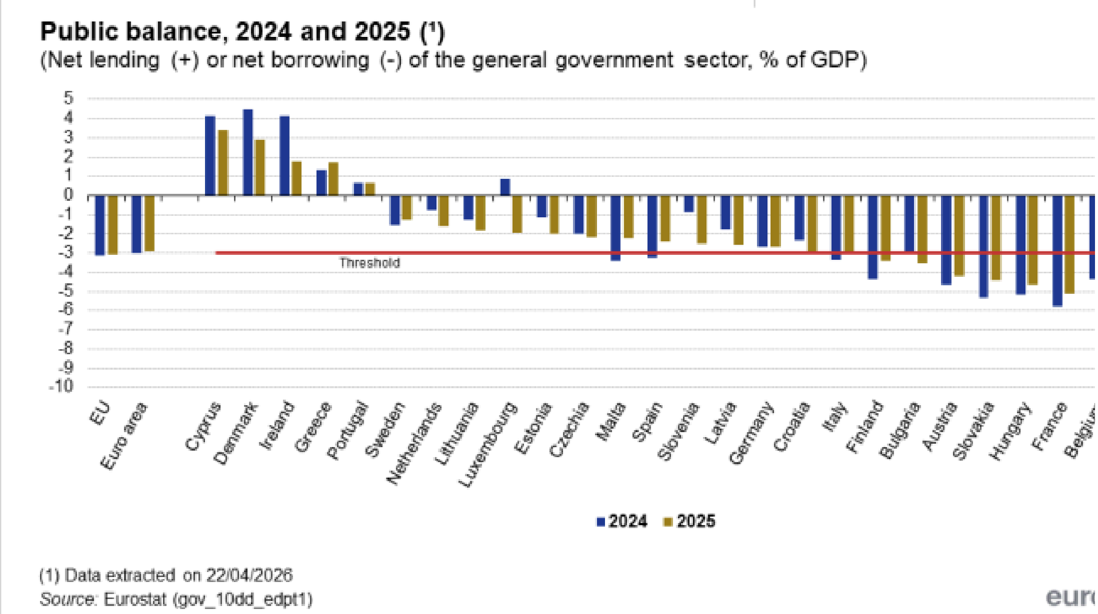


Figure 1: Public balance, 2024 and 2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10dd_edpt1)

The general government balance (in relation to GDP) decreased or remained stable for 15 EU Member States in

2025 compared with 2024 (meaning that the deficit increased in magnitude or the surplus decreased), while an increase was recorded for 12 EU Member States. The largest increases were noted in Romania (+1.4 percentage points (pp)), Malta (+1.2 pp), Finland and Slovakia (both +0.9 pp), while the largest decreases were noted in Luxembourg (-2.9 pp), Ireland (-2.4 pp), Slovenia (-1.7 pp) and Denmark (-1.6 pp).

Public balance and general government debt, 2022-2025 (¹)
(% of GDP)

	Public balance (net lending (+) or net borrowing (-) of the general government sector)				General government debt (general government consolidated gross debt)		
	2022	2023	2024	2025	2022	2023	2024
EU	-3.2	-3.4	-3.1	-3.1	82.4	80.5	80.7
Euro area 20	-3.4	-3.5	-3.0	-2.9	89.3	86.9	87.0
Euro area 21	-3.4	-3.5	-3.0	-2.9	88.9	86.5	86.6
Belgium	-3.5	-4.1	-4.4	-5.2	103.3	102.5	103.9
Bulgaria	-2.9	-2.0	-3.0	-3.5	22.5	22.9	23.8
Czechia	-3.1	-3.7	-2.0	-2.1	42.5	42.2	43.3
Denmark	3.4	3.4	4.5	2.9	33.3	33.0	30.5
Germany	-1.9	-2.5	-2.7	-2.7	64.4	62.3	62.2
Estonia	-0.9	-2.7	-1.1	-2.0	19.2	20.2	23.5
Ireland	1.6	1.4	4.1	1.8	43.0	41.8	38.3
Greece	-2.6	-1.4	1.3	1.7	177.8	164.3	154.2
Spain	-4.6	-3.3	-3.2	-2.4	109.3	105.2	101.6
France	-4.7	-5.4	-5.8	-5.1	111.4	109.5	112.6
Croatia	0.0	-1.1	-2.3	-3.0	68.5	60.9	57.4
Italy	-8.1	-7.1	-3.4	-3.1	138.4	133.9	134.7
Cyprus	2.7	1.7	4.1	3.4	80.1	71.1	62.7
Latvia	-4.9	-2.3	-1.8	-2.5	44.4	44.4	46.2
Lithuania	-0.7	-0.7	-1.3	-1.8	38.3	37.1	38.0
Luxembourg	0.2	-0.7	0.9	-2.0	24.9	24.7	26.3
Hungary	-6.2	-7.0	-5.1	-4.7	74.1	73.3	73.5
Malta	-5.3	-4.4	-3.4	-2.2	50.3	46.9	45.9
Netherlands	0.0	-0.4	-0.7	-1.6	48.4	45.8	43.8
Austria	-3.4	-2.6	-4.6	-4.2	78.1	77.8	80.0
Poland	-3.4	-5.2	-6.4	-7.3	48.8	49.5	54.8
Portugal	-0.3	1.1	0.6	0.7	111.2	96.9	93.5
Romania	-6.5	-6.6	-9.3	-7.9	48.1	49.3	54.8
Slovenia	-3.0	-2.6	-0.9	-2.5	72.8	68.3	66.4
Slovakia	-1.6	-5.3	-5.3	-4.5	57.8	55.8	59.7
Finland	-0.2	-2.9	-4.4	-3.4	74.0	77.0	82.4
Sweden	1.0	-0.9	-1.5	-1.3	34.4	32.2	34.2

(1) Data extracted on 22/04/2026
Source: Eurostat (gov_10dd_edpt1)

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Table 1: Public balance and general government debt, 2022-2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10dd_edpt1)

General government gross debt

In the EU, the government debt-to-GDP ratio increased from 80.7% at the end of 2024 to 81.7% at the end of 2025, and in the euro area it increased from 87.0% to 87.8% (see Figure 2).

At the end of 2025, the lowest ratios of government debt to GDP were recorded in Estonia (24.1%), Luxembourg (26.5%), Denmark (27.9%), Bulgaria (29.9%), Ireland (32.9%), Sweden (35.1%) and Lithuania (39.5%). A total of 12 Member States had government debt ratios higher than 60% of GDP, with the highest registered in Greece (146.1%), Italy (137.1%), France (115.6%), Belgium (107.9%) and Spain (100.7%).

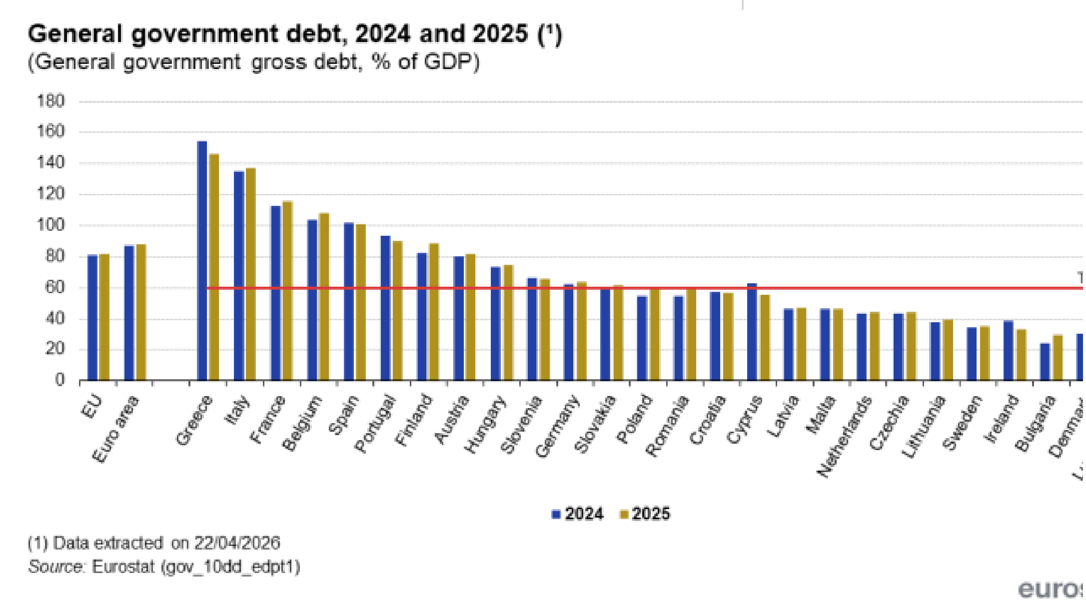

Figure 2: General government debt, 2023 and 2024
Source: Eurostat (gov_10dd_edpt1)

Compared with 2024, 19 Member States registered an increase in their debt to GDP ratio at the end of 2025 and 8 Member States a decrease at the end of 2025. The largest increases in the ratio were recorded in Finland (+6.2 pp), Bulgaria (+6.0 pp), Poland (+4.8 pp), Romania (+4.5 pp), Belgium (+3.9 pp) and France (+2.9 pp), while the largest decreases were observed in Greece (-8.0 pp), Cyprus (-7.7 pp), Ireland (-5.4 pp), Portugal (-3.8 pp) and Denmark (-2.6 pp).

At the level of the EU and euro area the increases in the debt to GDP ratio in 2025 are due to the increases in government debt slightly outweighing the increases in GDP in absolute terms. Debt increases when governments need to borrow in order to finance their deficits. Another important reason for an increase in government debt is the need for governments to finance the acquisition of financial assets. Further information is available in Eurostat's note on the stock-flow adjustment, describing the relationship between the deficit and the change in debt.

Government revenue and expenditure

The importance of the general government sector in the economy may be measured in terms of general government total revenue and total expenditure as a percentage of GDP. In 2025, government expenditure in the euro area was equivalent to 49.8% of GDP and government revenue to 46.9% of GDP. The figures for the EU were 49.5% and 46.4%, respectively. The government expenditure and revenue ratios increased in the EU and the euro area compared with 2024 — see Figure 3.

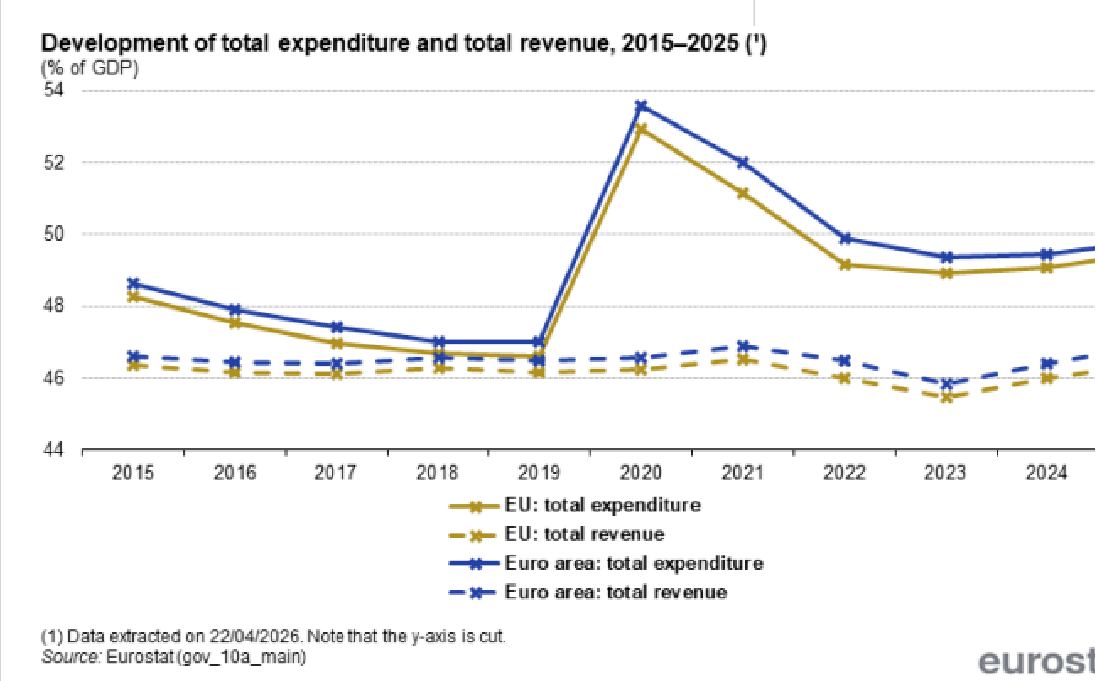

Figure 3: Development of total expenditure and total revenue, 2015–2025
Source: Eurostat [(gov_10a_main)](gov_10a_main)

Even before the increases in total expenditure as a percentage of GDP in both the EU and euro area in 2025, the levels remained above the long-term trends. In the period between 2015 and 2019, total expenditure as a percentage of GDP followed a decreasing trend in the EU and in the euro area. In 2020, the ratio increased by +6.6 pp in the euro area and +6.3 pp in the EU compared with the previous year. In 2021 and 2022, the ratio decreased strongly in the euro area and the EU. In 2023, the reduction of the general government total expenditure to GDP ratios by -0.2 pp in the EU and -0.5 pp in the euro area marked a less pronounced decrease as compared with the previous 2 years. In contrast, in 2024, government expenditure to GDP ratio in the euro area and EU increased by 0.1 pp and 0.2 pp respectively and in 2025 the growth accelerated further to 0.4 pp for both the euro area and EU.

In absolute terms, during the period from 2015 to 2018 in the euro area and the EU, general government total expenditure grew at a slower pace than general government total revenue, thereby leading to decreasing deficits. This trend stopped in 2019, when expenditure grew slightly faster than revenue in both the EU and the euro area, resulting in an increase in the deficit. In 2020, total revenue decreased by -3.7% in the EU and -4.1% in the euro area, while total expenditure increased by 9.2% in the EU and 9.0% in the euro area, the latter largely due to expenditure measures to mitigate the economic and social impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, for example by instituting or expanding furlough schemes and offering support to businesses. In 2020, the decrease in government total revenue was both due to automatic stabiliser effects of tax revenue (meaning that in an economic downturn, tax revenue decreases even without active policy measures) as well as due to active tax cutting measures in order to mitigate the economic downturn caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. In 2021, government revenue increased by 9.7% at the level of the EU and 9.4% at the level of the euro area, while expenditure increased by 5.3% at the level of the EU and 5.5% at the level of the euro area, reducing the gap between the two. This reduction in the gap continued in 2022, when government revenue increased by 8.0% at the level of the EU and 8.1% at the level of the euro area, while expenditure increased by 5.0% at the level of the EU and 4.6% at the level of the euro area. Despite the decreasing gap between total revenue and total expenditure, in 2022 and 2023, many countries government revenue and expenditure figures were strongly influenced by government measures to mitigate the impact of rising energy prices. In 2023, general government total revenue increased by 5.5% at the level of the EU and 5.1% in the euro area, while expenditure increased by 6.2% at the level of the EU and 5.5% in the euro area. In 2024, general government total revenue increased by 5.7% at the level of the EU and 5.2% in the euro area, while expenditure increased on slower pace, by 4.9% at the level of the EU and 4.1% in the euro area. In 2025, the general government total revenue increased at a slower pace by 5.4% at the level of the EU and 4.9% in the euro area, while growth of expenditure accelerated to 5.2% at the level of the EU and 4.6% in the euro area.

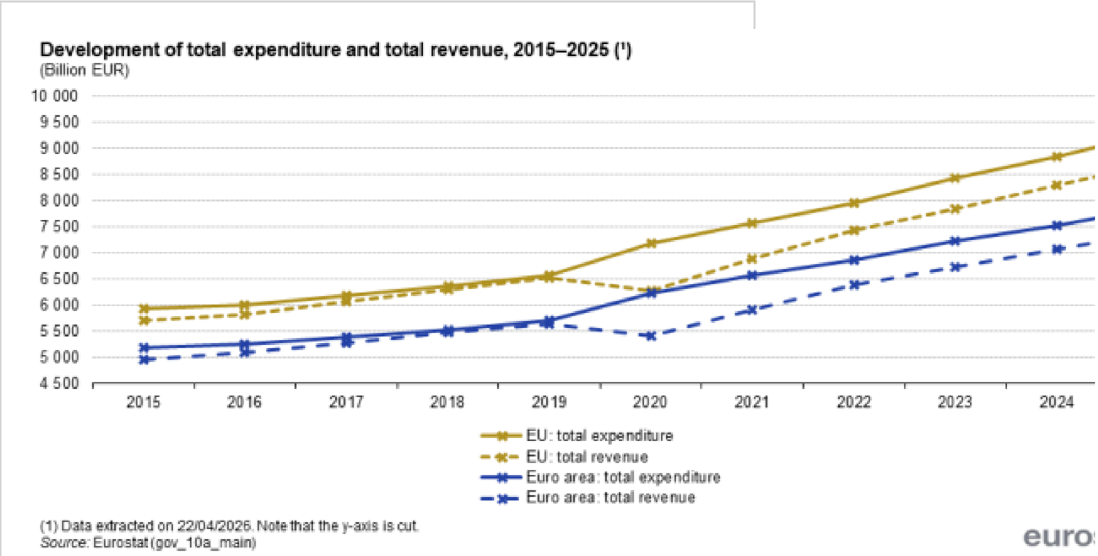

Figure 4: Development of total expenditure and total revenue, 2015–2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

While EU general government expenditure increased overall by €3 373 billion between 2015 and 2025, there was a €3 031 billion increase in EU general government total revenue in the same period. Between 2024 and 2025, EU government total expenditure increased by €461 billion, while government revenue increased by €445 billion. In the euro area, general government expenditure increased by €2 704 billion between 2015 to 2025, while total revenue increased by €2 456 billion. Between 2024 and 2025, both euro area government total expenditure and total revenue increased by €350 billion (see Figure 4).

The level of general government expenditure and revenue varies considerably between the EU Member States (see Figure 5). In 2025, the EU Member States with the highest levels of combined government expenditure and revenue as a proportion of GDP (in excess of 100%) were Finland, France, Austria and Belgium; Norway also recorded a ratio higher than 100%. In 2025, 4 EU Member States (Ireland, Malta, Romania and Bulgaria) reported relatively low combined ratios (less than 80% of GDP).

Components of general government total revenue

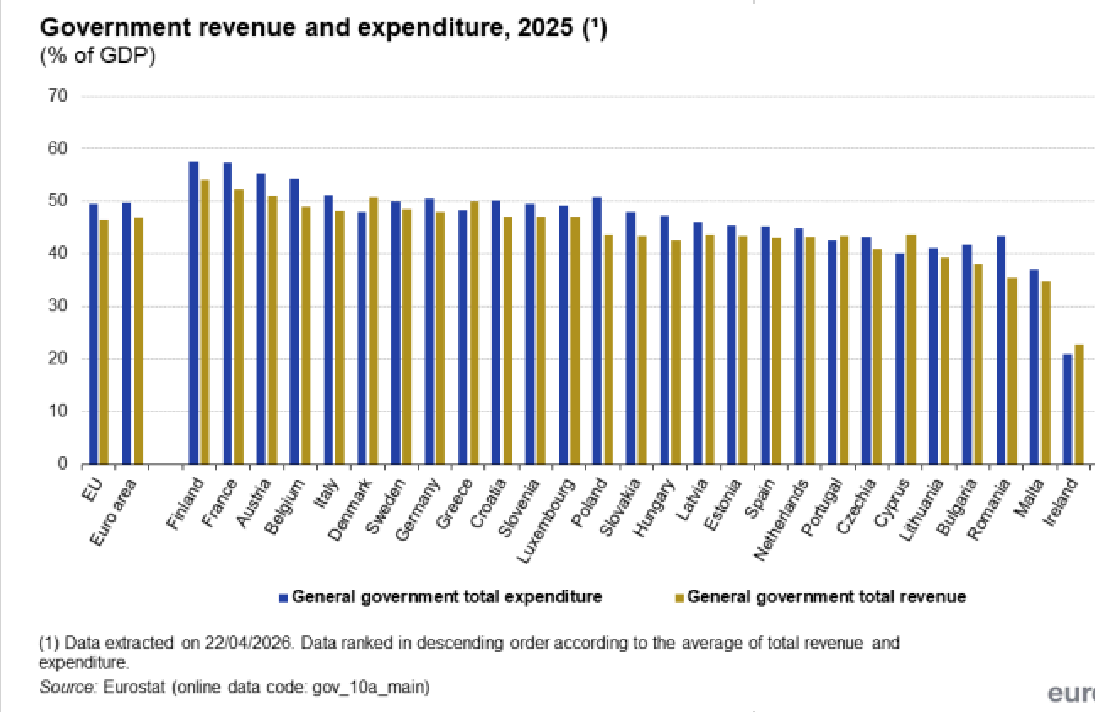

Figure 5: Government revenue and expenditure, 2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

Across the EU, the main components of total general government revenue are taxes and net social contributions (see Figure 6). In 2025, taxes made up 56.9% of total revenue in the EU and 55.8% in the euro area, while net social contributions amounted to 30.8% of total revenue in the EU and 32.3% in the euro area. Market output, output for own final use and payments for non-market production (sales/fees and own account capital formation) made up 7.4% of total revenue in the EU and 7.5% in the euro area. Property income (mainly interest, dividends and rent) made up 1.9% of total revenue in the EU and 1.7% of total revenue in the euro area.

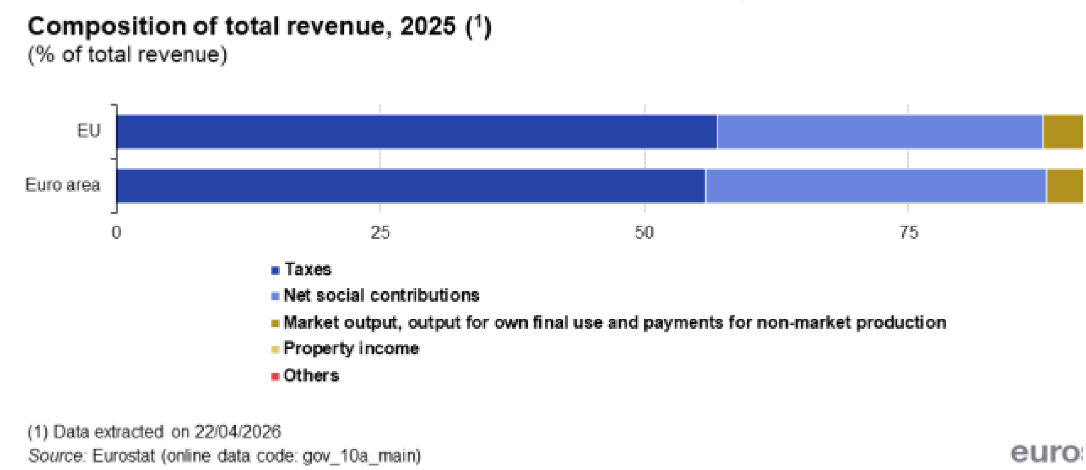

Figure 6: Composition of total revenue, 2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

Looking at each reporting country, the relative importance of the different revenue categories varied widely. Taxes made up less than 50% of general government total revenue in Slovenia (45.4%), Slovakia (46.4%), Czechia (47.2%), Germany (48.9%), Romania (49.3%) and Norway (49.3%) in 2025. By contrast, taxes made up 87.9% of general government total revenue in Denmark, 78.8% in Sweden, 77.0% in Ireland and 71.4% in Malta as well as 78% in Iceland.

Net social contributions had the highest shares in total revenue in 2025 in Germany and Czechia (both 38.4%), Slovenia (38.0%) and Slovakia (37.7%). The lowest shares of social contributions in total revenue were recorded in Denmark (1.3%) and Sweden (7.0%) as well as in Iceland (7.4%).

The highest share of property income was observed for Norway (28.0%), mainly due to revenue from oil and gas extraction.

In 2025, Bulgaria recorded the largest share of 'other revenue' (13.0% of total revenue), of which a significant share was due to current and capital transfers from the institutions and bodies of the EU. (see Figure 7).

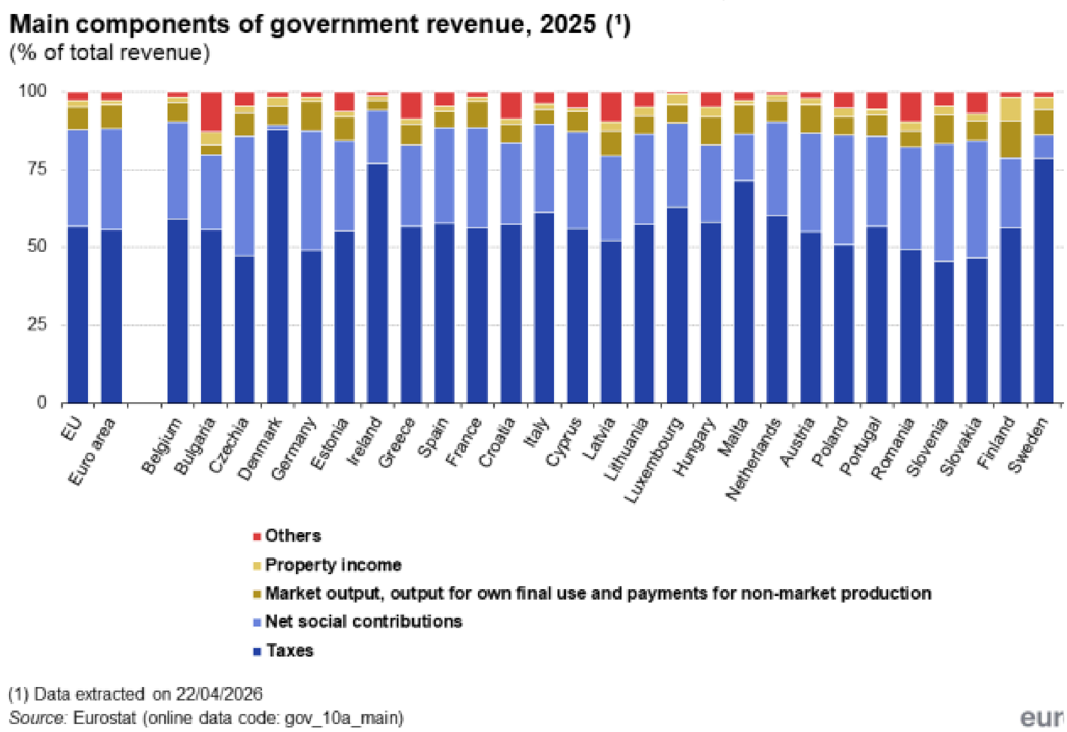

Figure 7: Main components of government revenue, 2025
Source: Eurostat [(gov_10a_main)](https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/bookmark/gov_10a_main)

Components of general government total expenditure

The largest proportion of EU government expenditure in 2025 concerned the redistribution of income in the form of social transfers in cash or in kind (see Figures 8 and 9).

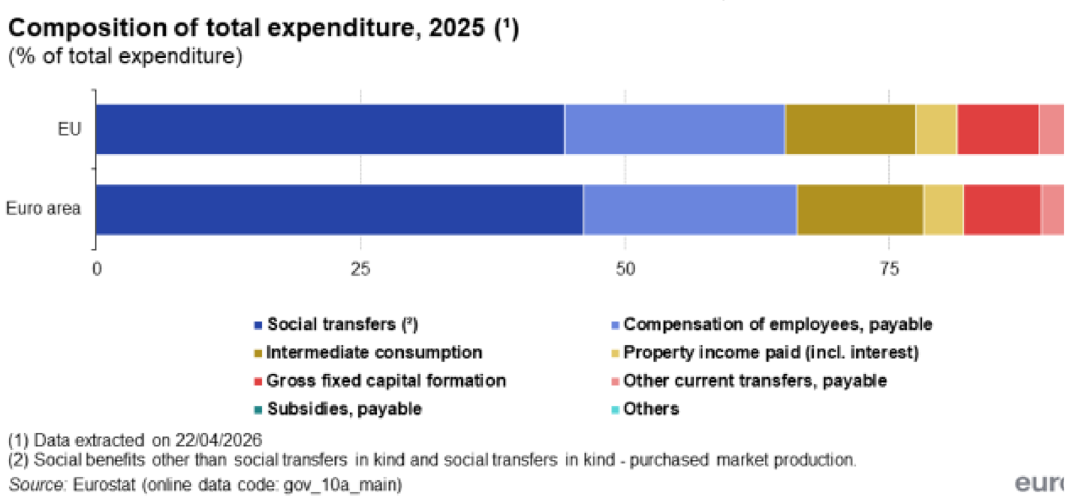

Figure 8: Composition of total expenditure, 2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

Social transfers (social benefits and social transfers in kind — purchased market production) made up 44.3% of total expenditure in the EU and 46.1% in the euro area. Compensation of employees (wages and salaries as well as employers' social contributions) accounted for 20.9% of government total expenditure in the EU and 20.2% in the euro area. Intermediate consumption (the purchase of goods and services needed for production) made up 12.4% of total expenditure in the EU and 12.0% of total expenditure in the euro area. Property income paid — of which by far the largest part is made up of interest payments — accounted for 3.9% of government expenditure in the EU and 3.8% of total expenditure in the euro area. Gross fixed capital formation (mainly investments in non-financial assets) accounted for 7.8% of total expenditure in the EU and 7.3% in the euro area. Subsidies made up 2.9% of government expenditure both in the EU and in the euro area. The share of subsidies in total expenditure increased significantly in 2020 and stayed at a high level throughout 2021 due to labour market support measures as well as other measures to mitigate the economic impact of the COVID-19 pandemic containment measures. The COVID-19 related subsidies largely decreased in 2022 and were no longer impacting expenditure in 2023 but were in 2022 and 2023 partly replaced by subsidies on products (e.g. electricity and petrol) and production (e.g. public transportation) to mitigate the impact of high energy prices. In 2025, at the level of the EU and euro area, subsidies make up a significantly smaller share of total expenditure than in preceding years.

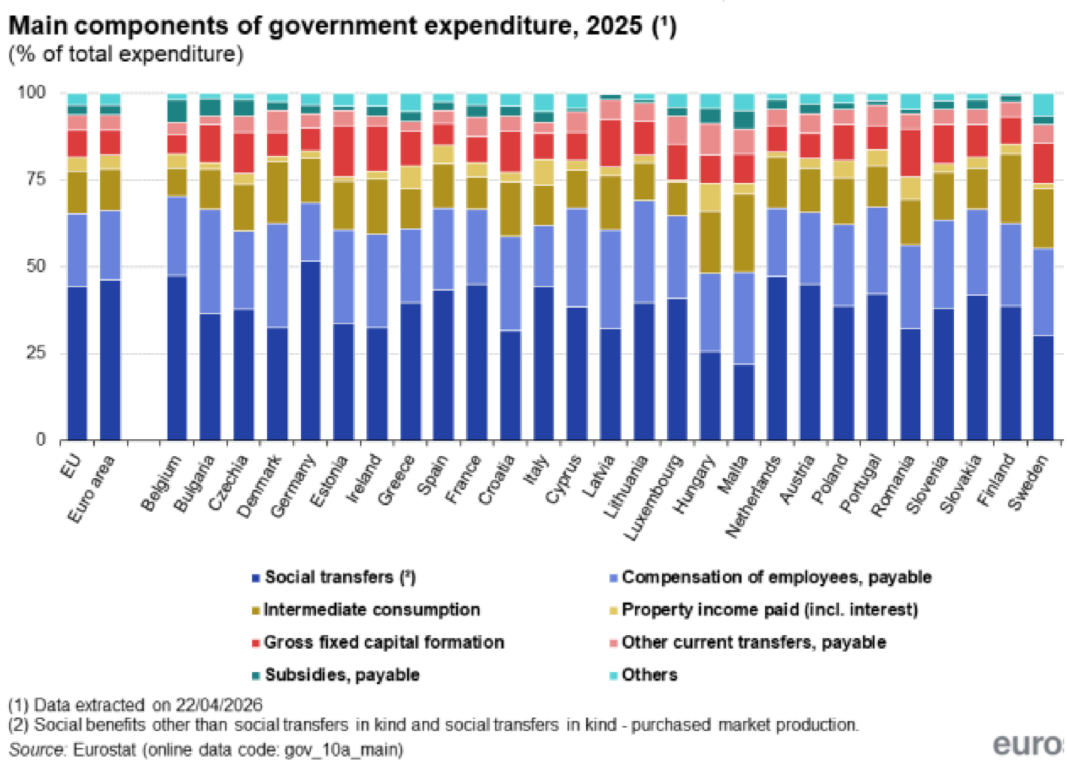

Figure 9: Main components of government expenditure, 2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

The highest shares of social transfers in total expenditure were observed in Germany (51.5%), Belgium (47.4%), the Netherlands (47.1%) while the lowest shares were observed in Malta (21.8%) and Hungary (25.4%) as well as in Iceland (21.0%).

In 2025, the share of subsidies in total expenditure was highest in Belgium (6.5%), followed by Malta (5.5%), Bulgaria (4.8%), Czechia (4.7%) and Hungary (4.5%).

In 2025, property income expenditure (mainly interest) had a share of more than 5% of total expenditure for Hungary (8.0%), Italy (7.6%), Romania (6.6%), Greece (6.5%) and Spain (5.3%) as well as Iceland (9.5%).

Taxes and social contributions

The main types of government revenue are taxes on production and imports, current taxes on income and wealth, etc., and net social contributions. For the EU, taxes on production and imports amounted to an equivalent of 12.8% of GDP in 2025, current taxes on income, wealth, etc. to 13.3% of GDP, and net social contributions to 14.3% of GDP.

Relative to GDP, the revenue from taxes on production and imports remained nearly stable as a ratio to GDP over the period 2015–2019 in the EU (see Figure 10). In 2020, the ratio decreased by -0.3 pp only to increase by 0.2 pp in 2021. In 2022 and 2023, taxes on production and imports relative to the GDP decreased by -0.3 pp and -0.5 pp respectively, while in 2024 and in 2025, the ratio remained unchanged compared to 2023 (12.8%).

With the exception of a dip in 2023 (13.0% of GDP), current taxes on income and wealth increased steadily from 12.7% of GDP in 2015 to 13.3% of GDP in 2025. Current taxes on income and wealth are dominated by personal income taxes, which remain relatively stable in comparison with corporate income taxes, that tend to fluctuate more from year to year.

Net social contributions remained comparatively stable as a ratio to GDP while following a slightly decreasing trend - ranging between 14.1% and 14.2% in the period between 2015 and 2019. In 2020, net social contributions increased to 14.5% of GDP. One of the reasons for the 2020 increase in net social contributions revenue was that many of the labour market support schemes and other social measures in the EU Member States to mitigate the economic and social impact of the COVID-19 pandemic ensured a continued coverage of contributions so that the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic was less pronounced than for taxes on production and imports. However, the following years (2021-2023), net social contributions as a ratio to GDP decreased to 13.7%. In 2024 at the level of the EU, net social contributions revenue stood at 14.0% of GDP, i.e. lower than the ratio before 2019, but a strong increase compared to 2023. The ratio increased further to 14.3% of GDP in 2025.

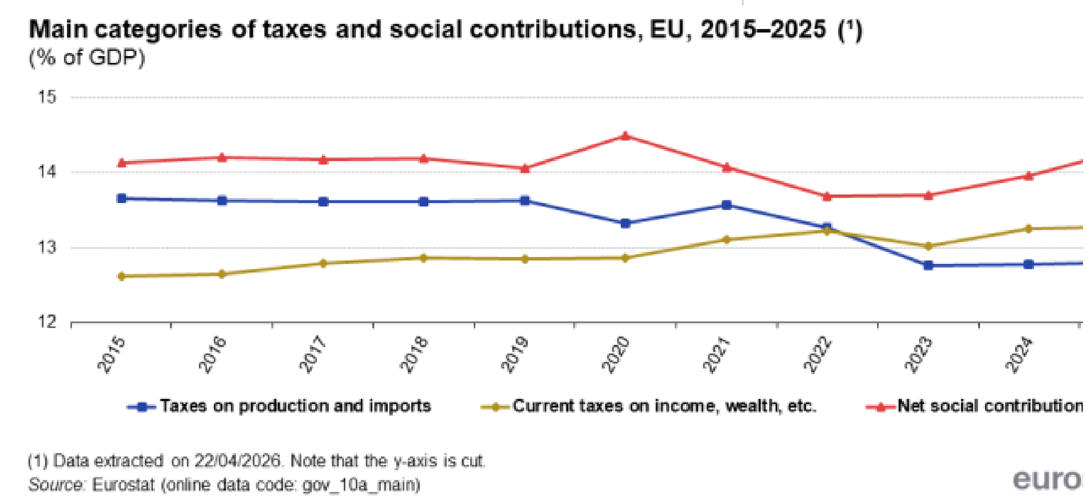

Figure 10: Main categories of taxes and social contributions, EU, 2015–2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

There was considerable variation in the structure of tax revenue across the EU Member States in 2025 (see Figure 11). As may be expected, those Member States that reported relatively high levels of expenditure tended to be those that also raised more taxes and social contributions (as a proportion of GDP) for general government. For example, in 2025, the highest revenue to GDP ratio from the main categories of taxes and social contributions was 45.4% of GDP recorded in France, followed by 45.1% recorded in Denmark, 44.1% of GDP in Austria, 43.5% of GDP in Belgium, 42.9% of GDP in Italy, 42.2% of GDP in Finland and 42.1% of GDP in Luxembourg. The proportion of GDP accounted for by such revenue was equal or below 30% in Ireland (21.2%), Romania (29.2%), Malta (29.8%) and Bulgaria (30.1%).

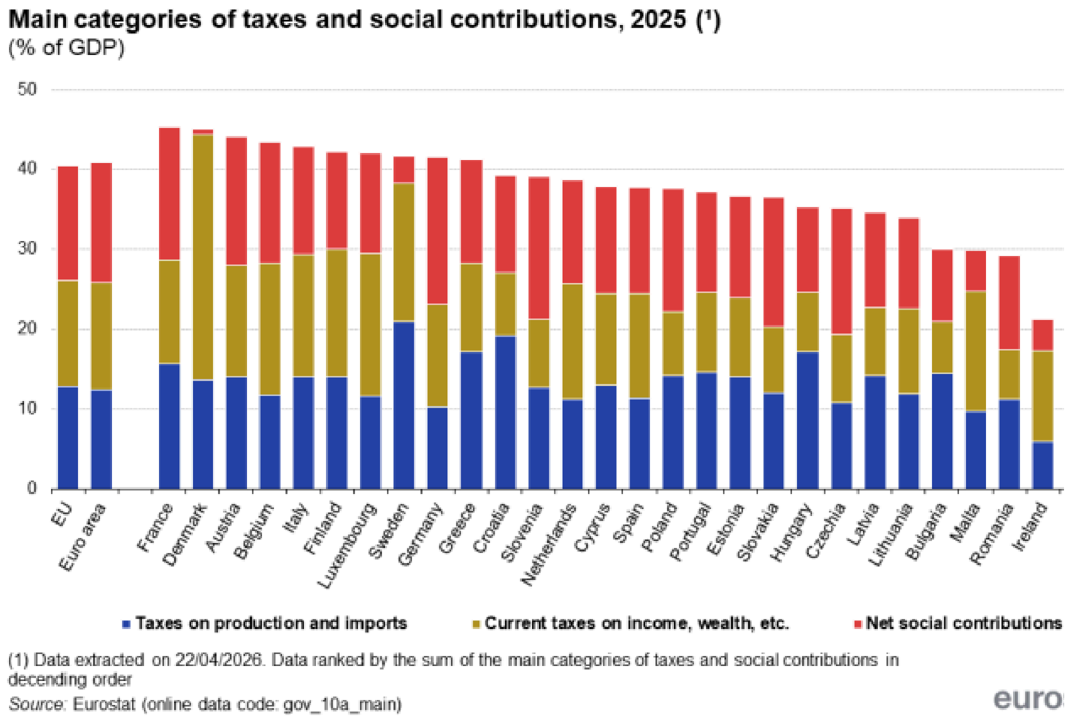

Figure 11: Main categories of taxes and social contributions, 2025
Source: Eurostat (gov_10a_main)

Source data for tables and graphs

- Government finance statistics: tables and figures

Data sources

Under the terms of the excessive deficit procedure, EU Member States are required to provide the European

Commission with their government deficit and debt statistics before 1 April and 1 October of each year. In addition, Eurostat collects more detailed data on government finance statistics within the framework of the transmission programme which results in the submission of national accounts data. The main aggregates for general government are provided to Eurostat twice a year, whereas statistics on the functions of government (COFOG) should be transmitted within eleven months after the end of the reference period and detailed tax and social contribution receipts within nine months after the end of the reference period. Data on the structure of general government gross debt is transmitted twice a year, with a slightly longer delay than for debt transmitted under the Excessive Deficit Procedure and quarterly debt. Quarterly non-financial and financial accounts, quarterly financial balance sheets as well as quarterly general government gross debt are provided four times a year.

The data presented in this article correspond to some of the main indicators of the general government sector, which are compiled on a national accounts (ESA 2010) basis.

The difference between total revenue and total expenditure — including capital expenditure (in particular, gross fixed capital formation) — equals net lending/net borrowing of general government, which is also one balancing item of the government non-financial accounts.

Delineation of general government

The general government sector consists of institutional units which are non-market producers whose output is intended for individual and collective consumption, and are financed by compulsory payments made by units belonging to other sectors, and institutional units principally engaged in the redistribution of national income and wealth (ESA 2010 §2.111). The general government sector is subdivided into four subsectors: central government, state government (where applicable), local government, and social security funds (where applicable).

Definition of main indicators

The public balance is defined as general government net borrowing/net lending reported for the excessive deficit procedure and is expressed in relation to GDP. According to the protocol on the excessive deficit procedure, government debt is the gross liabilities in currency and deposits, debt securities, and loans outstanding at the end of the year of the general government sector measured at nominal (face) value and consolidated.

The main revenue of general government consists of taxes, social contributions, sales and property income. It is defined in

ESA 2010 by reference to a list of categories: market output, output for own final use, payments for non-market output, taxes on production and imports, other subsidies on production, property income, current taxes on income, wealth, etc., net social contributions, other current transfers and capital transfers.

The main expenditure items consist of the compensation of (government) employees, social benefits (social benefits and social transfers in kind for market production purchased by general government), interest on the public debt, subsidies, and gross fixed capital formation. Total general government expenditure is defined in ESA 2010 by reference to a list of categories: intermediate consumption, gross capital formation, compensation of employees, other taxes on production, subsidies, property income, current taxes on income, wealth, etc., social benefits other than social transfers in kind, social transfers in kind - purchased market production, other current transfers, adjustments for the change in pension entitlements, capital transfers, and transactions in non-produced assets.

General government data reported for main aggregates of general government in the ESA 2010 framework must be consolidated for certain national accounts transactions, meaning that specific transactions between institutional units within the general government sector — property income, other current transfers and capital transfers — are eliminated or cancelled out. For these transactions, subsector data should be consolidated within each subsector but not between subsectors. Thus, data at the sector level should equal the sum of the subsector data, except for the items covering property income, other current transfers and capital transfers, which are consolidated. For these latter items, and consequently total revenue and total expenditure, the sum of the subsectors should exceed the value of the sector.

Taxes and social contributions correspond to revenues which are levied (in cash or in kind) by central, state and local governments, and social security funds. These levies (generally referred to as taxes) are organised into three main areas, covered by the following headings:

- taxes on income and wealth, etc. including all compulsory, unrequited payments levied periodically by general government on the income and wealth of enterprises and households;
- taxes on production and imports, including all compulsory, unrequited payments levied by general government with respect to the production and importation of goods and services, the employment of labour, the ownership or use of land, buildings or other assets used in production;
- net social contributions, including all employers' and households' actual social contributions, imputed social

contributions that represent the counterpart to social benefits paid directly by employers, as well as two additional imputed items (households' social contribution supplements and social insurance scheme services charges).

Context

The global financial and economic crisis of 2007-2008 resulted in serious challenges being posed to many European governments. The main concerns were linked to the ability of national administrations to be able to service their debt repayments, take the necessary action to ensure that their public spending was brought under control, while at the same time trying to promote economic growth.

The disciplines of the Stability and Growth Pact (SGP) are intended to keep economic developments in the EU, and the euro area countries in particular, broadly synchronised. Furthermore, the SGP is intended to prevent EU Member States from taking policy measures which would unduly benefit their own economies at the expense of others. There are two key principles to the SGP: namely, that the deficit (planned or actual) must not exceed 3% of GDP and that the debt-to-GDP ratio should not be more than (or should be falling towards) 60%. The SGP was substantially reinforced in 2011, as was EU economic governance in general. In 2024, a further review of the economic governance framework entered into force.

Each year, EU Member States provide the European Commission with detailed information on their economic policies and the state of their public finances. Euro area countries provide this information in the context of the stability programmes, while other Member States do so in the form of convergence programmes. The European Commission assesses whether the policies are in line with agreed economic, social and environmental objectives and may choose to issue a warning if it believes a deficit is becoming abnormally high. This action can lead to the Council finding the existence of an excessive deficit, which requires a deadline to be set for its correction.

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